

The 20-Minute AI Hygiene Check

AI tools increasingly do more than answer questions. They read your information, change records, send messages, and act through other systems. This is a short, deliberate look at what you've allowed — and what you'd rather not have allowed.

WHEN YOU'RE DONE, YOU'LL HAVE

A working inventory of the AI tools and connections you can identify — plus at least one thing you're going to review, reduce, or turn off.

01 The idea

Access is authority. The more a system can affect people, data, money, or customers, the more deliberately that authority should be granted. Not every connection deserves the same trust, so it helps to have a scale.

LEVEL	WHAT IT MEANS	TYPICAL EXAMPLE
1 · Read	Can view, cannot change.	Summarize documents, search files
2 · Draft	Prepares an action; a person decides.	Draft an email or proposal
3 · Write	Changes internal information.	Update a record, edit a file
4 · Send / Publish	Reaches the outside world.	Email a customer, post publicly
5 · Delete / Spend	Hard to reverse.	Delete records, buy things, run code
6 · Authorize	Grants authority to others.	Create logins, approve payments, start other automations

Levels 4 through 6 are where a person should usually still be in the loop.

02 Four places to look

Don't try to map everything. In twenty minutes, these four cover the most ground. Look for wording like **Connected apps**, **Third-party access**, **Authorized applications**, **Integrations**, **Linked accounts**, or **App permissions** — usually under Security, Privacy, Account, or Admin.

01 Your Google or Microsoft account

Many apps connected through "Sign in with Google" or "Sign in with Microsoft" can be reviewed from these account-level lists. One of the fastest places to start.

02 Your browser

Extensions can read pages and act inside sessions you're already signed into. Remove what you don't use.

03 Your automation platform

Zapier, Make, Power Automate, n8n. Look hardest at anything that sends, publishes, or changes records.

04 Your AI tools

Each one keeps its own connector list — email, calendar, files, CRM, code. Check them individually.

WHAT THIS FAST PASS WON'T CATCH

API keys and service accounts that may be managed elsewhere. Connections made with a username and password may not appear in your Google or Microsoft third-party access list. Tools set up on one person's computer. Integrations enabled inside another vendor's console. Anything an employee connected under a personal account. This is a starting point, not a clean bill of health.

03 For each one, ask

1. **What is it for?** If nobody can say why it exists, that's your answer.
2. **What can it read?** One folder, or everything?
3. **What can it change?** Create, edit, move, delete?
4. **Can it reach the outside world?** Email, messages, posting, publishing.
5. **Can it do something expensive or permanent?** Deletion, payments, code, production systems.
6. **Where does a person approve?** Does it recommend, draft, or just go?
7. **Could you stop it today?** Do you know where to click, and where the record of what it did lives?

04 Write it down

One row per connection. Keep it general — no passwords, no keys, no customer data. You're recording categories of authority, not secrets.

[illegible]

05 Red flags

If any of these are true, deal with them before you do anything else.

- Something has administrator access because that was the easy setting.
- A tool can email customers without review, and nobody deliberately approved that workflow.
- Something can delete, publish, buy, or deploy with no approval step.
- Nobody remembers why a connection exists or who set it up.
- An automation uses the owner's full access when narrower permissions would do.
- People are adding tools and extensions with no shared list.
- You can't say how to revoke a tool's access.
- Nothing is logged, or nobody knows where the logs are.

06 Then do one thing

A list nobody acts on is just a list. Before you close this page: remove one connection you no longer use, or take one thing down a level — write instead of send, draft instead of publish. Then put a date on the calendar to do this again. Choose a regular review date, and review again when important tools or permissions change.

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If you want a second set of eyes on what you found, or you're not sure what a particular connection can actually do, I'm happy to talk it through. Twenty minutes, phone or video.

The full briefing

Access is authority. Don't give AI more authority than the job requires. · This is practical operational guidance, not cybersecurity, legal, or compliance advice. Some situations need a qualified professional. · Menu names were current in September 2026; if one has moved, search that product's help for "connected apps."